links it to Raja Siri Satakarni, who authorised the work and lent his artisans. This was probably Siri Satakarni who ruled for twenty-nine years from about 150 CE. But Siri Satakarni was the last powerful ruler of his dynasty. Although six more named Satavahana rulers followed him, their empire was now being worn away at the edges as one feudatory after another broke away: first the so-called Western Satraps in the west, then the Kadambas and the Ikshvakus in the central regions, and finally the Pallavas, who became the new powers in the deep south.

That these Satavahanas were highly cultured rulers is exemplified by Raja Hala, listed in the *Matsya Purana* as the seventeenth ruler of their dynasty. Hala compiled an anthology of poetry originally written in early Maharashtrian Prakrit entitled *Gaha Sattasai*, or 'Seven hundred songs' (in Sanskrit, *Gathasaptasati*), which included some forty of Hala's own poems, which have something of the Japanese haiku form about them in their compressed delicacy. These were first edited by the German Sanskritist Albrecht Weber in 1881 and some have since been translated into English by the distinguished American poet and translator Andrew Schelling. One of Raja Hala's poems in Schelling's translation reads as follows:

> *Mother*
> *with the blink of an eye*
> *his love vanished*
> *A trinket gets*
> *dangled*
> *into your world*
> *you reach out and it's gone.*[6]

The Satavahanas are, to my mind, the most undervalued of all the great dynasties of kings who ruled India, not least because of the early Buddhist revival that began under their protection. Their very name had been all but lost to history